

Bridge Principles without UG: Projectibility, Crosslinguistic Evidence, and Linguistic Ontology

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Abstract

Crosslinguistic argument is not methodologically innocent. If evidence from one language is used to analyse another, some bridge principle is needed to explain why the evidence travels. This paper accepts that constraint but rejects the stronger claim that only a Chomskyan Universal Grammar can supply the bridge. Universal Grammar is one proposed license for evidential travel, not the condition of possibility for linguistic comparison as such. A projectibility-based account instead asks what a proposed category lets us infer, at what explanatory level, under which contrasts, and through which stabilizers. The result is a pluralist realism about linguistic targets: mental grammars, public standards, usage profiles, typological comparanda, and norm-governed varieties can all be real enough for inquiry when their projection targets and failure conditions are explicit.

Keywords: Universal Grammar; projectibility; linguistic ontology; crosslinguistic evidence; bridge principles

1 INTRODUCTION: BRIDGE PRINCIPLES, NOT BOUNDARY POLICING

The central issue is not whether one may compare English, French, Japanese, Yoruba, or Warlpiri. The issue is what licenses a particular comparison. The starting concession is substantial: linguistic categories do not announce themselves from raw speech, text, or judgments, and evidence from one language does not automatically bear on another. The disagreement is with the monopoly claim that crosslinguistic evidence is licensed only by a genetically specified Universal Grammar.

2 WHAT REISS GETS RIGHT

First, theoretical linguistics can be empirical without being experimental, corpus-based, or statistical. Second, categories such as word, sentence, negative-polarity item, segment, syllable, and wh-element are theory-mediated. Third, crosslinguistic inference needs a warrant. These concessions matter because they make the disagreement narrower and stronger: the reply is not anti-theoretical, anti-realist, or anti-comparative.

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3 THE MONOPOLY CLAIM

The vulnerable step is the move from bridge principles to Universal Grammar as the only possible bridge. The chapter moves among several claims: languages are comparable; individual mental grammars are real objects; relevant primitives are innate and genetically specified; data from one language can bear on another; only Universal Grammar licenses that evidential travel. The paper will argue that the last claim does not follow from the earlier ones.

4 BOUNDARY STIPULATION AND DISCIPLINARY ONTOLOGY

The chapter's restricted use of *linguists* is methodologically important. If *linguists* means Chomsky and those who broadly share his philosophical stance, disagreement with Universal Grammar can be redescribed as external to linguistics rather than as an internal dispute over objects, methods, and evidential warrants. A stipulated restriction may be harmless when reconstructing a research programme. It becomes problematic when used to draw conclusions about what linguists as such are entitled to do.

5 PROJECTIBILITY AS AN ALTERNATIVE LICENSE

A projectibility account asks what the category lets us project, for which purposes, under which contrasts, and at which level of explanation. Evidential travel can be licensed by shared projection targets, stabilizing mechanisms, acquisition and transmission bottlenecks, recurrent communicative pressures, diachronic pathways, population-level conventions, typological recurrence, or independent linkage evidence. The question is not whether these licenses are all equally strong. It is whether Universal Grammar is the only possible license.

6 PUBLIC AND DISTRIBUTED LINGUISTIC OBJECTS

The I-language object restriction is legitimate inside a Chomskyan programme, but it should not settle the ontology of the discipline. Public, community-level, and normatively regimented objects need not be compact individual substances to be scientifically tractable. Their tractability can come from maintenance, uptake, correction, transmission, institutionalization, and projectibility.

7 CONCLUSION

Crosslinguistic inference requires bridge principles; it does not require Chomskyan Universal Grammar. The positive task is to make those bridge principles explicit enough to test, compare, and demote. On that view, Universal Grammar is one proposed projectibility profile for linguistic evidence, not the master condition for doing linguistics.

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